

DATA ROOM: CASE FOR PRESIDENTIAL PARDON Keonne Rodriguez and William Lonergan Hill

Developers of Samourai Wallet Prepared for:

President Donald J. Trump and White House Staff

Date: July 2026

Purpose: To provide a comprehensive, accurate, and actionable briefing supporting a full and unconditional presidential pardon.



Executive Summary

Keonne Rodriguez (age ~37, Harmony, PA) and William Lonergan Hill (age 67, U.S. national previously in Portugal) are the co-founders of Samourai Wallet, a non-custodial Bitcoin privacy tool. They were sentenced in November 2025 to 5 and 4 years in federal prison, respectively, after pleading guilty to conspiracy to operate an unlicensed money transmitting business.²⁸

Core Facts:

; Samourai is non-custodial: Users retain full control of their private keys. The developers wrote and maintained open-source software; they did not hold or transmit user funds.

; The wallet included privacy features like Whirlpool (a CoinJoin mixer) that enhance Bitcoin transaction privacy by breaking on-chain links.

; Prosecutors alleged facilitation of over \$2 billion in transactions, including \$237 million in criminal proceeds (darknet markets, drugs, fraud, etc.). Developers earned and forfeited fees (\$6.3 million).

; They pleaded guilty to the lesser charge; the more serious money laundering conspiracy was dropped.³⁶

Why a Pardon Is Warranted:

- This case represents a significant expansion of criminal liability to software developers for creating privacy-enhancing tools, contrary to longstanding FinCEN guidance distinguishing non-custodial software from regulated money transmission services.
- It threatens First Amendment protections for code as speech and chills open-source innovation and financial privacy tools in the United States.
- The developers are first-time offenders with no prior criminal history. The sentences are disproportionate.
- President Trump has already demonstrated a commitment to correcting overreach in the crypto space by pardoning or commuting sentences for Changpeng “CZ” Zhao (Binance), Ross Ulbricht (Silk Road), and BitMEX founders.⁴⁸

A pardon would:

- Restore legal clarity between software development and financial intermediation.
- Protect American technological leadership in privacy and blockchain.
- Appeal strongly to the 50+ million crypto voters, libertarians, and independents.
- Carry near-zero marginal political cost.

Recommendation: Grant full and unconditional pardons to both individuals, including relief from remaining supervised release, fines, and forfeiture obligations where appropriate. This corrects a misapplication of law and advances pro-innovation, pro-privacy policies.

The Draft Pardon Document

EXECUTIVE ORDER

GRANTING PARDONS TO KEONNE RODRIGUEZ AND WILLIAM LONERGAN HILL

By the authority vested in me as President by the Constitution and the laws of the United States of America, it is hereby ordered as follows:

Section 1. I hereby grant a full and unconditional pardon to Keonne Rodriguez and William Lonergan Hill for any and all offenses against the United States of America arising out of or related to their development, marketing, or operation of Samourai Wallet, including but not limited to violations of 18 U.S.C. § 1960 (unlicensed money transmitting business) and related conspiracy charges.

Section 2. This pardon restores all civil rights forfeited as a result of these convictions.

Section 3. The Attorney General is directed to take all necessary actions to implement this Order, including vacating any remaining supervised release, fines, or forfeiture obligations associated with these matters.

Section 4. This Order is effective immediately.

Donald J. Trump
President of the United States

[Date]

Trump's Private Angle

- Feuds with prior administration's DOJ/SDNY overreach align with narratives of correcting weaponized justice.
- Career/political benefit: Positions Trump as the pro-innovation, pro-privacy President who delivers for a growing voter bloc.
- Low downside: Precedents already set with CZ, Ulbricht, and BitMEX pardons. Minimal new political risk.

Political Breakdown

Beneficiaries & Political Upside:

- Crypto community (50+ million American voters per Stand With Crypto data): Strong support for privacy tools and ending regulatory overreach. Many are independents and libertarians.
- Bitcoiners and privacy advocates: Core base that values financial sovereignty and code as speech.
- Tech/innovation sector: Signals that the U.S. welcomes privacy-enhancing and open-source development rather than driving it offshore (to China, etc.).
- Groups “humiliated” by reversal: Critics of privacy tools and overzealous prosecutors appear overly punitive.

Congressional Angle: Highlight races where crypto voters can swing outcomes. Include Stand With Crypto talking points on pro-innovation policy. A pardon demonstrates follow-through on “war on crypto is over” messaging and builds goodwill ahead of midterms.

Trump's Public Angle – Talking Points & Draft Communications

Key Messages for President Trump:

- “I am pardoning the developers of Samourai Wallet because this case went too far. They wrote software for financial privacy code is speech. We don't jail people for building tools that protect Americans' rights.”
- “The Biden administration weaponized the justice system against crypto innovators. My administration is ending the war on crypto and restoring common sense.”
- Response to reporters: “These are software developers, not money launderers. They didn't hold customer funds. FinCEN guidance supported their work. It's time to correct this injustice and protect American innovation.”

Draft Social Media / Announcement: “Today I am granting full pardons to Keonne Rodriguez and William Hill, the developers behind Samourai Wallet. They built privacy tools for Bitcoin users. Enough with the overreach. America leads in technology — we don't criminalize our coders.
#FreeSamourai #Crypto

What We Can Offer

- Photo opportunities: High-profile crypto executives and leaders (e.g., Brian Armstrong of Coinbase, other industry figures) willing to participate in a public event with the President celebrating the pardon and American innovation.
- Public support & amplification: Endorsements, podcasts, social media from major crypto voices and organizations (Bitcoin Policy Institute, Coin Center, Stand With Crypto allies).
- Potential financial/political support: Crypto community gratitude expressed through legitimate channels (PACs, donations where appropriate).
- Coalition building: Opportunity to bundle with other crypto-related clemency matters for broader impact and efficiency (single signature).

Exhaustive Legal Analysis

Part 1: Devil's Advocate – Acknowledging the Government's Case (Bulletproof Credibility)

- Samurai Wallet facilitated mixing services (Whirlpool) used by some individuals for illicit purposes.
- Prosecutors documented over \$237 million in traceable criminal proceeds flowing through the service.
- The developers marketed privacy features, operated a coordinator service, charged fees, and were aware that privacy tools can obscure transaction trails.
- They ultimately pleaded guilty to operating an unlicensed money transmitting business knowing it transmitted crime proceeds.
- The service handled significant volume, and some promotional/outreach aspects were cited by prosecutors.

Part 2: Strongest Arguments for Pardon

1. Non-Custodial Nature & FinCEN Guidance: Users always controlled their own keys. No third party took custody or transmitted funds on their behalf. FinCEN's own analysis reportedly concluded such architectures do not constitute money transmission.³⁹
2. Code as Speech & First Amendment: Developing and publishing open-source software is protected expression (Bernstein v. United States precedent). Criminalizing software authors for how users later employ the code sets a dangerous precedent.
3. Misapplication of Law & Disproportionate Punishment: This expands criminal liability far beyond traditional money transmitters. First-time offenders received multi-year prison sentences for writing privacy software. Contrast with large banks receiving primarily financial penalties in major laundering cases.

Part 3: Additional Arguments

- Chilling effect on U.S. developers of privacy, security, and blockchain tools.
- Users of privacy tools include legitimate actors (journalists, activists, ordinary citizens seeking financial privacy).
- The plea and sentencing occurred under prior administration policies; a new approach is warranted.
- Pardon aligns with restoring rule of law and correcting regulatory inconsistency.

Part 4: Propaganda / Human Element







Emphasize: These are software developers and entrepreneurs, not career criminals. One is a senior citizen; the other a first-time offender. The punishment does not fit the “crime” of building privacy software. Contrast the resources of the SDNY with the individuals involved.

Bold Re-Framing of the Argument

This case is not primarily about money laundering. It is about technological progress, financial privacy, and the future of American innovation.

- Bitcoin’s public ledger creates new challenges for privacy — inventors responded with tools like CoinJoin/Whirlpool.
- Code is speech. Banning or criminalizing the creation of privacy tools is the modern equivalent of prosecuting inventors of encryption or privacy-enhancing technologies.
- Historical parallels: Inventors and thinkers (Socrates, Galileo, and others) were prosecuted by authorities of their day for advancing knowledge.
- The Constitution protects privacy rights. Overly broad application of money transmission laws to non-custodial software undermines these protections.

- Technology wins wars and drives prosperity (Turing, Manhattan Project, modern computing). America should back its coders and inventors — not drive elite talent and innovation offshore or underground.
- A pardon restores law and order by correcting an overreach and reaffirms that the United States champions technological freedom.

References & Sources (All links verified/current as of July 2026)

- DOJ Sentencing Press Release:
<https://www.justice.gov/usao-sdny/pr/founders-samurai-wallet-cryptocurrency-mixing-service-sentenced-five-and-four-years>
- Bitcoin Policy Institute Analysis:
<https://www.btcpolicy.org/articles/pardoning-the-samurai-developers-would-correct-a-misapplication-of-federal-law-and-protect-the-future-of-non-custodial-software>
- Advocacy: <https://billandkeonne.org/>
- Wikipedia & Court Summaries (for background): Keonne Rodriguez page and related DOJ filings.
- Trump Crypto Pardons: Multiple reports on CZ, Ross Ulbricht, BitMEX (BBC, Reuters, etc.).
- FinCEN-related arguments and defense filings referenced in CoinDesk, Money Laundering Watch, etc.
- Stand With Crypto and broader industry resources.